



“Can I pick your brain?”

A quick guide to handling requests for free advice, work or barter arrangements

The mindset: you are routing, not refusing>>

- The question is a compliment and a lead, never a nuisance. You are not saying no; you are moving the conversation to the proper channel.
- Talk freely about the **what** (what we do, what is possible, what the general science says). Redirect the **how** (anything applied to their specific site, soil, product or business). The “how” is consultancy.
- Free advice is uncoded staff time and uninsured guesswork. Paid advice through Hutton Scientific Services protects the enquirer as well as us.

What to say>>

Your go-to line:

“That’s a really good question, and it deserves a better answer than I can give you off the cuff. That’s exactly what our consultancy side, Hutton Scientific Services, does properly. Can I take your details and get the right person to set up a call?”

The event or corridor grab:

“I could give you a guess now, but you’d be better off with the real answer. Let me connect you with our commercial team, they’ll tell you honestly what’s needed”

The email “quick question”:

“Happy to point you in the right direction. For anything specific to your situation we’d handle that through Hutton Scientific Services, so you get proper, defensible advice rather than my best guess.”

The barter offer (site access, land or kit in exchange for work):

“That’s interesting, and we do have partnership routes for exactly this. They’re assessed centrally so we can look at the science value properly. Send me the details and I’ll put it into the process.”

Golden rules

- **Always capture contact details.** “let me get you to the right person” starts a conversation.
- **Let the process do the declining.** Partnership and barter offers go into a formal assessment. You’re not the decision maker.
- **“Let me check and come back to you” is always allowed.** You never have to answer on the spot.
- **Pass every enquiry on.** Even the ones that go nowhere help us understand demand.